MPI LANCHESTER–OSIPOV

Potential conflicts: flashpoints and participants

An analysis of 20 flashpoints as of October 2026: balance of forces, the Lanchester model's view, escalation risks, indicators and scenario settings.

Document 4 of 5 · Conflicts

Data cut-off: October 2026 · Open sources
Military power assessment programme for states · project documentation

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Summary

The document examines each flashpoint of a potential or ongoing conflict separately: what is happening, who is involved and with which allies, what the balance of forces is, what the model shows, where the risk of escalation lies, which indicators to monitor, and how to set up the scenario in the programme. The flashpoints are ordered by risk level.

Flashpoint	Status	Escalation risk	Nuclear factor	Model regime
Russia — Ukraine	war under way	very high	Russia — nuclear	positional war of attrition
Israel and the United States — Iran	intermittent war, naval blockade	very high	Israel, United States — nuclear; Iran — threshold (before the strikes)	air and missile campaign and sea denial
Ethiopia — Eritrea (+ Tigray)	war in Tigray, threat of interstate war	very high	none	interstate and civil war
Israel — Hezbollah, Gaza, Syria, the Houthis	multi-front operations	high	Israel — nuclear	counter-insurgency and mixed model
The Strait of Hormuz and the naval blockade of Iran	blockade and incidents	high	US — nuclear	sea denial, salvo model
Pakistan — Afghanistan	open armed conflict since February 2026	high	Pakistan — nuclear	asymmetric war (mixed law)
DR Congo — Rwanda (M23)	combat operations in eastern DR Congo	high	none	proxy war
Russia and Belarus — NATO (eastern flank)	hybrid confrontation	medium (hybrid threats — high)	both sides — nuclear	deterrence; risk of a rapid local strike
India — Pakistan	fragile truce after May 2025	medium / high	India (about 190), Pakistan (about 170)	a short war below the nuclear threshold
China — Taiwan (+ United States, Japan)	military pressure, exercises	medium (blockade — higher, invasion within the next year — lower)	China (about 620), United States — nuclear	amphibious operation or blockade
China — Philippines (South China Sea)	clashes in the grey zone	medium (grey zone — high)	China, US — nuclear	grey zone, coast guard
North Korea — South Korea (+ United States)	tension, North Korean troops in Russia	medium	North Korea (about 60), United States — nuclear	deterrence; risk of an artillery and missile strike
China — Japan	diplomatic and military crisis	medium / low	China — nuclear; Japan — under the US “umbrella”	deterrence, maritime incidents
Thailand — Cambodia	fragile truce	medium / low	none	border conflict
India — China	normalisation after the 2024 agreement	low / medium	both — nuclear	high-altitude border conflict
Serbia — Kosovo	chronic tension	low / medium	none	—
Greece — Türkiye	disputes in the Aegean Sea	low / medium	none (NATO nuclear participation in Türkiye)	maritime and air incident
Armenia — Azerbaijan	peace treaty initialled	low	none	—
United States — Venezuela (after the January 2026 operation)	transitional period	low (interstate)	US — nuclear	post-conflict stabilisation
Greenland (United States — Denmark)	September 2026 agreement	low (crisis settled)	US, allies — nuclear	crisis within the alliance

Main conclusions

1. **Three flashpoints in an active-war phase with a risk of expansion:** Russia — Ukraine, Israel and the United States — Iran (with the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz), Ethiopia — Eritrea.

2. **Asymmetric and hybrid forms prevail.** Drones, strikes on infrastructure, sea denial, the grey zone in the South China Sea. That is why the programme needs not only Lanchester's laws but also the Deitchman mixed law, the salvo model and an incident monitor.
3. **The nuclear factor limits targets but does not rule out war.** India — Pakistan, Russia — NATO, North Korea — South Korea: wars are possible in a limited form, and the programme sets this through a constraint on the scenario's objectives.
4. **Allied reliability is the main uncertainty.** The position of the United States in Europe and Asia, guarantees to Ukraine, China's intervention — that is why the coalition module (document 3) is key to flashpoint analysis.
5. **The model is tested by reality.** The positional war in Ukraine, the rapid suppression of Iran's air defence and the instant outcome of the operation in Venezuela match the calculations given the right α, d and coalitions.

Limitations. the escalation risk assessment is an expert one, as of October 2026. Events develop quickly, so the flashpoint monitor in the programme is updated at least once a month. Data on losses and production in ongoing wars come from the parties and are not independently verified.

1. States — flashpoint participants

Country	Military expenditure 2025, billion $ (% of GDP)	Nuclear weapons	Flashpoints	Key alliances
China	≈ 336 (1.7)	≈ 620	Taiwan, Japan, Philippines, India	without military alliances; a partnership with Russia
India	92.1 (2.3)	≈ 190	Pakistan, China	strategic autonomy; Quad
Saudi Arabia	≈ 83.2 (6.5)	—	Iran, Houthis	treaty with Pakistan (2025); a partnership with the United States
Japan	62.2 (1.4)	— (US umbrella)	China, North Korea	alliance with the US
South Korea	47.8 (2.6)	— (US umbrella)	North Korea	alliance with the US
Poland	46.8 (4.5)	—	Russia and Belarus	NATO, EU
Türkiye	30.0 (1.9)	— (NATO nuclear participation)	Greece, Middle East	NATO; Azerbaijan
Taiwan	18.2 (2.1)	—	China	US Taiwan Relations Act
Pakistan	11.9 (2.9)	≈ 170	India, Afghanistan	China; Saudi Arabia
Greece	8.4 (3.0)	—	Türkiye	NATO, EU; France
Finland	8.1 (2.6)	—	Russia	NATO, EU, JEF
North Korea	no data	≈ 60	South Korea; participation in Russia's war	treaty with Russia (2024)
Belarus	not in the top 40	Russian nuclear weapons on its territory	NATO (Suwałki Gap)	Union State, CSTO
Philippines	not in the top 40	—	China	treaty with the United States (1951)
Afghanistan (Taliban)	no data	—	Pakistan	—
Ethiopia, Eritrea	not in the top 40	—	each other, Tigray	—
DR Congo, Rwanda	not in the top 40	—	eastern DR Congo, M23	—
Thailand, Cambodia	not in the top 40	—	border	ASEAN; Thailand — a US ally
Armenia, Azerbaijan	not in the top 40	—	peace process	Azerbaijan — Türkiye; Armenia — CSTO membership frozen
Serbia, Kosovo	not in the top 40	—	northern Kosovo	KFOR (NATO)
Venezuela	not in the top 40	—	transitional period; Guyana	—

Expenditure — SIPRI Fact Sheet, April 2026 (≈ — SIPRI estimate). Nuclear weapons — SIPRI Yearbook 2026, January 2026.

2. Russia — Ukraine

Escalation risk: very high. **Status:** war under way. **Nuclear factor:** Russia — nuclear. **Model regime:** positional war of attrition.

Status as of October 2026

- A full-scale war since February 2022, now in its fifth year. The front line has shifted slowly for years; the sides are waging an intensive war of long-range strikes (energy, refineries, ports, data centres).
- On 11 October 2026 the US president announced an “energy truce”; Kyiv reported that strikes continued. Earlier Ukraine had proposed a 60-day full ceasefire to hold elections.
- Russia: the authorised strength of service members has been increased to 1,550,500; recruitment is estimated at about 30 thousand per month and declining; a new mobilisation is under discussion. The Ukrainian side reports high Russian losses (the parties' estimates are not independently verified).
- Ukraine: mass production of drones (more than 4 million in 2025, a plan of 7–10 million in 2026), long-range strikes; mobilisation difficulties. The “coalition of the willing” has undertaken to deploy forces after a ceasefire.

Balance of forces

Russia has the advantage in the mass of ground forces, artillery, nuclear arsenal, size of the economy and depth. Ukraine — in drones, C4ISR, defence advantage and allied support. MPI: Russia ≈ 63, Ukraine ≈ 47; in the theatre, allowing for force shares — about 1.7 : 1 in favour of Russia (document 3, section 5.2).

What the model shows

The saturation of the battlefield with drones has raised the defence coefficient d to 2.5–3. At α ≈ 1.3, a breakthrough requires 2–2.3 : 1, and the actual ratio is lower. The model predicts slow progress by the attacker and a war of attrition, where manpower, production and the economy decide. This matches the observed course of the war.

Escalation risks

- A shift to a protracted war until one of the sides exhausts its human or economic resources
- Incidents with NATO: drone incursions into Poland, Romania, the Baltics and Finland
- Nuclear rhetoric
- Breakdown or consolidation of the truce

Indicators for monitoring

- Recruitment versus losses (Russia) and mobilisation (Ukraine)
- Monthly output of shells, drones and interceptors
- Strikes on refineries and export ports; Russia's budget revenues
- The volume of EU aid and procurement for Ukraine
- Negotiations on a ceasefire and guarantees

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Sides: Russia (+ North Korea, Belarus) against Ukraine (+ allied supply; after the truce — coalition forces). α = 1.0; d = 1.7 — measured from equipment losses in 2024–2025 (Oryx, document 6, section 7.7); horizon 365 days; mobilisation included; weight preset “Protracted war”.

3. Israel and the United States — Iran

Risk of escalation: very high. **Status:** war with interruptions, naval blockade. **Nuclear factor:** Israel, the United States — nuclear weapons; Iran — threshold (before the strikes). **Model mode:** air-and-missile campaign and sea denial.

Status as of October 2026

- US and Israeli strikes from 28 February 2026 (the US operation Epic Fury was completed on 5 May). Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei, the IRGC commander and the defence minister were killed; on 8 March Mojtaba Khamenei was appointed Supreme Leader.
- A ceasefire mediated by Pakistan — 8 April; a memorandum on 60-day talks — June; fighting resumed on 8 July. The US naval blockade — from 13 April to 18 June and again from mid-July.
- According to US intelligence (May 2026), Iran has retained about 70% of its pre-war missile stockpile and launchers and has restored access to most underground bases. CENTCOM claims that up to 90% of the defence industry has been hit; the estimates contradict each other.

Balance of forces

The coalition's overwhelming superiority in air force, intelligence, missile defence and power projection. Iran has missiles and drones in shelters, the threat to the Strait of Hormuz, and territory and mountains.

What the model shows

Coalition calculation (document 3, section 5.1) — about 6.8 : 1 in favour of Israel and the United States; the model predicts rapid suppression of air defence and the air force, which is what happened. But the outcome is not determined by the balance in c.u.: what matters is the survivability of the underground missile arsenal (salvo model), the cost exchange of a “cheap missile against an expensive interceptor”, and sea denial in the Strait of Hormuz.

Escalation risks

- Resumption of full-scale war
- Strikes on the energy infrastructure of the Persian Gulf
- Involvement of Hezbollah and the Houthis
- Restoration of the nuclear programme or a nuclear breakout

Indicators for monitoring

- The pace of Iranian missile and drone launches
- Interceptor expenditure by Israel and the United States
- Shipping through the Strait of Hormuz and blockade operations
- Talks on the nuclear programme

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Israel ($s = 0.7$) + the United States ($\rho = 0.9$, $s = 0.2$, $D = 1$ thousand km from bases in the region) against Iran + the “Axis of Resistance”. Models: Lanchester for the air campaign ($d = 1.2–1.5$) + the salvo model for missile strikes and missile defence.

4. Ethiopia — Eritrea (+ Tigray)

Escalation risk: very high. **Status:** war in Tigray, threat of interstate war. **Nuclear factor:** none. **Model regime:** interstate and civil war.

Status as of October 2026

- Fighting has resumed in northern Ethiopia between federal troops and an opposition alliance that Addis Ababa believes is backed by Eritrea. On 3 October 2026 the Ethiopian army took Mekelle.
- Eritrea has severed diplomatic relations with Ethiopia. Analysts assess the risk of a full-scale war in the coming weeks as high; on 3 October the US State Department called for restraint.
- Chatham House warns of the risk of the war spreading to Eritrea and Sudan.

Balance of forces

Ethiopia is many times superior in population and army numbers; Eritrea is a highly militarised state with mountainous terrain and war experience.

What the model shows

A mountainous theatre with a high d; an offensive against Eritrea will require significant superiority. Drones (Ethiopia's experience of 2021–2022) and human resources are taken into account.

Escalation risks

- Invasion of Eritrea
- A regional war involving Sudan
- Humanitarian catastrophe in Tigray

Indicators for monitoring

- Troop movements towards the border
- Mediation by the African Union and the US

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Ethiopia against Eritrea (+ Tigray forces); α = 1.0; d = 1.0 — fortified defence according to the methodology table (from CDB90 battles); horizon 180 days.

5. Israel — Hezbollah, Gaza, Syria, the Houthis

Escalation risk: high. **Status:** multi-front operations. **Nuclear factor:** Israel — nuclear. **Model regime:** counter-insurgency and mixed model.

Status as of October 2026

- Hezbollah re-entered the fighting on 2 March 2026; the Israel Defense Forces launched a ground operation in Lebanon and took positions along the border.
- A ceasefire agreement is in force in Gaza, but operations continue. After the fall of the Assad regime Israel controls strategic areas in Syria, including Mount Hermon.
- Israel's defence budget for 2026 has been increased to about 144 billion shekels; the daily cost of the war was estimated at 1.5–1.7 billion shekels.

Balance of forces

Israel's complete superiority in conventional forces; its opponents rely on dispersion, tunnels, missiles and drones.

What the model shows

The Deitchman mixed law: a regular army delivers “area fire” against a concealed enemy, while the latter delivers aimed fire. The superiority required is many times higher, and the outcome is determined by duration and sustainment (reservists, the economy) rather than by the balance of power.

Escalation risks

- A war of attrition with overstretched reservists
- Missile and drone strikes on the rear
- Linkage with the Iranian front

Indicators for monitoring

- Mobilisation of reservists and their fatigue
- Rate of missile attacks
- Budget supplements and US aid

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Deitchman model; horizon 180–365 days; the “Protracted war of attrition” preset; reservists accounted for (P02, L16).

6. The Strait of Hormuz and the naval blockade of Iran

Escalation risk: high. **Status:** blockade and incidents. **Nuclear factor:** United States — nuclear. **Model regime:** sea denial, salvo model.

Status as of October 2026

- Since mid-July 2026, US forces, according to Gulf News as of 11 October, have deployed 135 vessels, disabled 4 vessels that tried to break the blockade and destroyed 10 tankers linked to the IRGC.
- In August the commander of the IRGC Navy declared the strait closed; the United States says the strait is open and the mines have been cleared.
- Before the war, about 25% of the world's seaborne oil trade passed through the strait.

Balance of forces

Overwhelming superiority of the US Navy; Iran has boats, mines, anti-ship missiles, drones and coastal positions.

What the model shows

The Hughes salvo model: the outcome depends on the number of missiles in a salvo, interception and the survivability of ships. The key indicator is the cost exchange. Cheap sea-denial means create a threat out of proportion to the size of the fleet.

Escalation risks

- A strike on a tanker or ship with heavy casualties
- Mine warfare
- An oil price spike and the involvement of the Gulf states

Indicators for monitoring

- Number of incidents and detentions of vessels
- Insurance rates and traffic through the strait
- IRGC stocks of anti-ship missiles and mines

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Salvo model: US Navy + partners against the IRGC Navy; indicators N09, N08, D09; cost exchange accounted for.

7. Pakistan — Afghanistan

Risk of escalation: high. **Status:** open armed conflict since February 2026. **Nuclear factor:** Pakistan — nuclear weapons. **Model mode:** asymmetric war (mixed law).

Status as of October 2026

- The conflict began with Pakistani strikes on camps of the Pakistani Taliban (TTP) and ISIS-K in Afghanistan (21 February 2026); Pakistan declared “open war”.
- UN: at least 372 civilians killed and 397 injured in Afghanistan in the first quarter of 2026. The March ceasefire has been broken; fighting resumed on 18 September, and on 24 September Pakistan struck 10 targets.
- China's mediation has so far been unsuccessful.

Balance of forces

Pakistan is fully superior in aviation, artillery and the economy; the Taliban — in irregular warfare and mountainous terrain.

What the model shows

Deitchman mixed law: aviation against a dispersed opponent is of low effectiveness, and a ground operation requires many times the superiority. The model predicts a protracted conflict without a decisive outcome.

Escalation risks

- Pakistan's ground operation
- Growing TTP terrorism inside Pakistan
- Humanitarian catastrophe

Indicators for monitoring

- Air and drone strikes
- TTP attacks
- Mediation by China, Qatar and Türkiye

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Deitchman model; horizon 180 days; terrain coefficient d = 3.

8. DR Congo — Rwanda (M23)

Escalation risk: high. **Status:** combat operations in eastern DR Congo. **Nuclear factor:** none. **Model regime:** proxy war.

Status as of October 2026

- Fighting continues in several areas despite the agreement between Kinshasa and Kigali in Washington (2025) and a separate deal between M23 and the government in Qatar.
- In March 2026 the United States imposed sanctions on the Rwandan army and four senior officers for supporting M23. Human Rights Watch reports forced recruitment.
- More than 7 million internally displaced persons in DR Congo (UN data).

Balance of forces

The DR Congo army is numerous but weak in quality and command; M23, with Rwanda's support, surpasses it in combat capability.

What the model shows

Quality matters more than numbers: with a large gap in e (quality) a small force retains the initiative. Rwanda's proxy involvement is modelled as an ally with ρ = 0.8 and s = 0.2.

Escalation risks

- Expansion of M23's control zone
- A direct clash between the DR Congo and Rwandan armies

Indicators for monitoring

- Implementation of agreements
- Sanctions and their effect

Setting up the scenario in the programme

DR Congo against M23 + Rwanda (ρ = 0.8); horizon 180 days.

9. Russia and Belarus — NATO (eastern flank)

Risk of escalation: medium (hybrid threats — high). **Status:** hybrid confrontation. **Nuclear factor:** both sides — nuclear weapons. **Model mode:** deterrence; risk of a rapid local strike.

Status as of October 2026

- Drone incursions into NATO airspace: Poland (September 2025), the Baltics and Finland (March–September 2026), Romania (April 2026). The attribution of some incidents is disputed.
- In September 2026 Belarus held exercises near the Suwałki Gap — 104 km of the Polish–Lithuanian border, the only land link between the Baltics and the rest of NATO.
- The NATO summit in Ankara (7–8 July 2026) called Russia a long-term threat. Poland spends about 4.5% of GDP, and Latvia has enshrined a minimum of 5% in law from 2027. Germany has deployed an armoured brigade in Lithuania.

Balance of forces

The combined power of the European NATO members is many times greater than Russia's, and even more so together with the United States. But a significant part of Russia's forces is tied up by the war with Ukraine, while NATO deploys with a delay.

What the model shows

Coalition calculation (document 3): European allies against Russia and Belarus — about 2.2 : 1, with the United States — about 2.8 : 1. The key variable is time: in the first 7–14 days the local ratio at the Suwałki Gap may favour the attacker, and by day 30 — favour NATO. The nuclear axis constrains the objectives of both sides.

Escalation risks

- A limited strike on the Baltics in the expectation of splitting the alliance
- Escalation from an accidental incident with a drone or aircraft
- Sabotage of infrastructure (cables, power)

Indicators for monitoring

- Concentration of forces in Kaliningrad and Belarus
- Frequency of drone incursions and airspace violations
- Deployment time of forward-presence forces
- NATO unity (disputes over spending, the US position)

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Russia (s = 0.4) + Belarus against Poland, the Baltics, Northern Europe, Germany, the United Kingdom and France (+ the United States with ρ = 0.7 and τ = 14 days). Horizon 60 days; nuclear mode — constraint on objectives.

10. India — Pakistan

Risk of escalation: medium / high. **Status:** fragile truce since May 2025. **Nuclear factor:** India (about 190), Pakistan (about 170). **Model mode:** short war below the nuclear threshold.

Status as of October 2026

- After the terrorist attack in Pahalgam (April 2025) India conducted Operation “Sindoor”; a ceasefire was then established. Trade and diplomatic ties remain largely suspended.
- On 16 September 2026 — an incident involving a collision of ships; in early October — the death of two civilians on the border, and the sides summoned diplomats.
- Military expenditure in 2025: India — 92.1 billion $, Pakistan — 11.9 billion $ (SIPRI). Pakistan concluded a mutual defence treaty with Saudi Arabia (2025).

Balance of forces

India is superior in the economy, the navy and numbers; Pakistan has nuclear weapons with a doctrine of early use and China's support.

What the model shows

The nuclear axis limits the war to short strikes (days): the “limited objective” model. The air force, air defence, long-range missiles and intelligence decide (roles AIR, C4I).

Escalation risks

- A new major terrorist attack as a trigger
- Escalation in the air with aircraft losses
- Nuclear escalation if Pakistan faces defeat

Indicators for monitoring

- Terrorist attacks in Kashmir
- Incidents on the line of control and at sea
- The position of China and Saudi Arabia

Setting up the scenario in the programme

India against Pakistan (+ China, $\rho = 0.1–0.2$); horizon 7–14 days; nuclear regime — limited objectives.

11. China — Taiwan (+ United States, Japan)

Risk of escalation: medium (blockade — higher, invasion within the next year — lower). **Status:** military pressure, exercises. **Nuclear factor:** China (about 620), the United States — nuclear weapons. **Model mode:** amphibious operation or blockade.

Status as of October 2026

- PLA exercises “Justice Mission–2025” around Taiwan (late December 2025) after the sale of US weapons to Taiwan worth 11 billion $.
- Taiwan practised repelling a naval blockade for the first time in the “Han Kuang” exercises (August 2026). For 12–17 October China announced exercises off its own coast, not near Taiwan.
- China has the world's second-largest military budget (about 336 billion $ in 2025); Taiwan — 18.2 billion $ (SIPRI).

Balance of forces

China's enormous superiority in absolute power; Taiwan has a strait 130–180 km wide, mountains, a fortified coast and the support of the United States and possibly Japan.

What the model shows

An amphibious operation is the extreme case of a high d (sea crossing, landing on a fortified coast): the required ratio is 3–5 : 1 and above at the landing sectors. A blockade is a war of sustainment: what decides is Taiwan's energy and food stocks (L14, L15, L20) and the ability of the United States and Japan to break the blockade (projection λ, navy).

Escalation risks

- A blockade or “quarantine” without open war
- An incident between ships or aircraft of the United States, Japan and China
- Linkage with the crisis in Japan and the Philippines

Indicators for monitoring

- Scale and proximity of exercises
- Concentration of landing assets
- Position of the US and Japan
- Taiwan's energy stocks

Setting up the scenario in the programme

China against Taiwan + the United States (ρ = 0.6–0.7) + Japan (ρ = 0.4–0.6); two branches — “amphibious operation” (d = 4) and “blockade” (horizon 90–180 days, preset “Protracted war”).

12. China — Philippines (South China Sea)

Risk of escalation: medium (grey zone — high). **Status:** clashes in the grey zone. **Nuclear factor:** China, the United States — nuclear weapons. **Model mode:** grey zone, coast guard.

Status as of October 2026

- July 2026: clashes at Second Thomas Shoal (two injured Philippine service members) and at Scarborough Shoal — three incidents in a week.
- 18 September — ramming of a vessel of the Philippine fisheries agency near Palawan; 3 October — interception of a Philippine aircraft by a J-16 fighter over Scarborough.
- Negotiations on a code of conduct in the South China Sea are stalled.

Balance of forces

Overwhelming superiority of China; the Philippines has a mutual defence treaty with the United States (1951).

What the model shows

The grey zone is described not by Lanchester but by the intensity of incidents. The threshold for crossing into war is the use of weapons against military personnel, which brings in the treaty with the US ($\rho = 0.6$–0.7).

Escalation risks

- Deaths of service members and the invocation of the treaty with the United States
- Blockade of garrison supplies

Indicators for monitoring

- Frequency and nature of incidents
- US presence in the Philippines

Setting up the scenario in the programme

The “Flashpoint monitor” module (incident intensity) + a scenario of China against the Philippines and the United States at sea.

13. North Korea — South Korea (+ United States)

Risk of escalation: medium. **Status:** tension, North Korean troops in Russia. **Nuclear factor:** North Korea (about 60), the United States — nuclear weapons. **Model mode:** deterrence; risk of an artillery and missile strike.

Status as of October 2026

- According to Seoul's estimate, North Korea has sent to Russia about 15 thousand combat service members and more than 6 thousand engineers and construction workers; an expansion of the contingent is under discussion.
- In September 2026 Kim Yo Jong threatened “more offensive” actions in response to US exercises; a mine explosion in the demilitarised zone was reported. President Lee Jae-myung put forward a new dialogue initiative.
- SIPRI estimates North Korea's arsenal at about 60 warheads.

Balance of forces

South Korea and the United States surpass North Korea in all pillars except the numbers of ground forces, artillery at the border and nuclear weapons.

What the model shows

The first day — an artillery and missile strike on Seoul (salvo model); thereafter — the overwhelming superiority of the allies. The nuclear axis limits the objectives.

Escalation risks

- A limited provocation at sea or in the DMZ
- Nuclear test
- Combat experience of North Korean troops in Russia improves their quality

Indicators for monitoring

- Missile launches
- Return of troops from Russia
- Allied exercises

Setting up the scenario in the programme

North Korea against South Korea + the United States; horizon 30 days; salvo model for the first strike.

14. China — Japan

Risk of escalation: medium / low. **Status:** diplomatic and military crisis. **Nuclear factor:** China — nuclear weapons; Japan — under the US “umbrella”. **Model mode:** deterrence, maritime incidents.

Status as of October 2026

- The escalation followed remarks by Prime Minister S. Takaichi about a possible Japanese military response to an attack on Taiwan. China imposed export restrictions on Japanese organisations.
- The Japanese destroyer “Ikazuchi” passed through the Taiwan Strait on 17 April 2026; China responded with patrols in the East China Sea and ships off Okinawa. In its 2026 Diplomatic Bluebook Japan downgraded the status of its relations with China.

Balance of forces

China is superior in scale; Japan — a technologically advanced navy and air defence, and an alliance with the United States.

What the model shows

Maritime and air theatre: roles NAV, AIR, C4I; the US–Japan alliance with $\rho = 0.7–0.8$.

Escalation risks

- Incident at the Senkaku Islands
- Involvement in the Taiwan crisis

Indicators for monitoring

- Incidents in the air and at sea
- Export restrictions, rare earth metals

Setting up the scenario in the programme

China against Japan + the United States; maritime theatre, D small for both sides.

15. Thailand — Cambodia

Escalation risk: medium / low. **Status:** fragile truce. **Nuclear factor:** none. **Model regime:** border conflict.

Status as of October 2026

- Fighting in May, July and December 2025: at least 101 killed, and more than half a million displaced on both sides. A ceasefire — since 27 December 2025.
- Cambodia accuses Thailand of occupying territory after the ceasefire. The leaders met in May 2026; on 9 October 2026 International Crisis Group noted signs of a “thaw”.

Balance of forces

Thailand is superior in air force, armour and the economy.

What the model shows

A local border theatre; aviation and artillery decide. Mediation (the United States, China, ASEAN) limits the objectives.

Escalation risks

- New clashes at disputed temples
- Nationalist mobilisation

Indicators for monitoring

- Border incidents
- Return of displaced persons

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Thailand against Cambodia; horizon 30 days.

16. India — China

Escalation risk: low / medium. **Status:** normalisation after the 2024 agreement. **Nuclear factor:** both — nuclear. **Model regime:** high-altitude border conflict.

Status as of October 2026

- After the clash in the Galwan Valley (2020), the sides agreed in 2024 to disengage troops in disputed sectors of the Line of Actual Control. In 2025–2026 relations are gradually normalising; no new large clashes have been recorded.

Balance of forces

China is superior in the economy and in infrastructure near the border; high mountains give the defence a large advantage.

What the model shows

Very high d (high mountains, logistics): local clashes without major operations.

Escalation risks

- Patrol incident
- Linkage with the India–Pakistan crisis

Indicators for monitoring

- Construction of infrastructure near the border
- Talks on the line of control

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Mountainous theatre, d = 3–4, horizon 30 days.

17. Serbia — Kosovo

Escalation risk: low / medium. **Status:** chronic tension. **Nuclear factor:** none. **Model regime:** —.

Status as of October 2026

- Serbia does not recognise Kosovo's independence. No reliable data on new major incidents in 2026 could be found; the KFOR presence remains.

Balance of forces

Serbia is significantly stronger than Kosovo, but the presence of NATO forces (KFOR) rules out a military solution.

What the model shows

Deterrence through the presence of a third party: the scenario is blocked by KFOR forces (ρ high).

Escalation risks

- Incidents in northern Kosovo

Indicators for monitoring

- EU-mediated dialogue
- KFOR strength

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Flashpoint monitor.

18. Greece — Türkiye

Risk of escalation: low / medium. **Status:** disputes in the Aegean Sea. **Nuclear factor:** none (NATO nuclear participation in Türkiye). **Model mode:** maritime and air incident.

Status as of October 2026

- Türkiye held major naval exercises “Denizkurdu-I” on 20–24 September 2026, including in the Aegean Sea and the Eastern Mediterranean. Greece calls on Ankara to withdraw its threat of war in the event of an extension of territorial waters.
- Both countries are NATO members; Greece has a mutual assistance treaty with France (2021).

Balance of forces

Türkiye is larger in numbers and defence industry (military expenditure of 30.0 billion $ versus 8.4 billion $; SIPRI 2025), Greece — the defensive geography of its islands and an alliance with France.

What the model shows

A conflict within the alliance: the coalition module detects the conflict of interest (both are in NATO) and uses the Greece–France alliance.

Escalation risks

- An incident in the air or at sea

Indicators for monitoring

- Airspace violations
- Continental shelf exploration

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Greece + France (ρ = 0.5) against Türkiye; maritime theatre.

19. Armenia — Azerbaijan

Escalation risk: low. **Status:** peace treaty initialled. **Nuclear factor:** none. **Model regime:** —.

Status as of October 2026

- In August 2025 in Washington the parties signed a joint declaration and initialled the peace treaty. Signature awaits an amendment to Armenia's constitution.
- Armenia opened transit for Azerbaijani trucks to Türkiye.

Balance of forces

Azerbaijan is superior in the economy and the armed forces; an alliance with Türkiye (Shusha Declaration).

What the model shows

Once the treaty is signed, the scenario moves to the archive; monitoring is via the “Flashpoint monitor”.

Escalation risks

- Failure of the constitutional reform in Armenia

Indicators for monitoring

- Referendum and signing of the treaty
- Operation of transport corridors

Setting up the scenario in the programme

An archived scenario; tension indicator.

20. United States — Venezuela (after the January 2026 operation)

Escalation risk: low (interstate). **Status:** transitional period. **Nuclear factor:** United States — nuclear. **Model regime:** post-conflict stabilisation.

Status as of October 2026

- On 3 January 2026 the United States conducted an operation with strikes on air defences and the capture of N. Maduro; Venezuela reported the deaths of 47 service members and 32 Cuban citizens.
- According to the Congressional Research Service, the United States controls sales of Venezuelan oil; an amnesty law has been adopted, some political prisoners have been released, and ties with Cuba and Iran have been weakened.

Balance of forces

Overwhelming US superiority.

What the model shows

An example of an extremely large force ratio and of the role of multipliers (intelligence, EW, special operations): the outcome in hours.

Escalation risks

- Internal instability
- The Essequibo dispute with Guyana

Indicators for monitoring

- Transitional government
- Armed groups

Setting up the scenario in the programme

An archived scenario for model validation.

21. Greenland (United States — Denmark)

Escalation risk: low (crisis settled). **Status:** the September 2026 agreement. **Nuclear factor:** United States, allies — nuclear. **Model regime:** crisis within the alliance.

Status as of October 2026

- In early 2026 the United States threatened allies with tariffs until the “purchase” of Greenland; the tariffs were then cancelled. Denmark strengthened its troops on the island, and Europe supported Denmark.
- In September 2026 the United States, Denmark and Greenland signed a trilateral security agreement with an expansion of the US military presence (including elements of the Golden Dome missile defence); the island's status was preserved.

Balance of forces

Not a military but a political crisis within the alliance.

What the model shows

An example of a decline in ρ within an alliance: the programme records such events in the ally reliability log.

Escalation risks

- Renewed escalation

Indicators for monitoring

- Implementation of the agreement

Setting up the scenario in the programme

Ally reliability log (ρ adjustment for the United States in NATO).

22. Internal wars with external participation

The civil war in Sudan, conflicts in the Sahel, Somalia and Myanmar are internal wars with external sponsors. The interstate index does not describe them. In the programme they are covered by the Deitchman mixed law, by accounting for external supplies as an ally with the “supply” contribution type, and by the flashpoint monitor indicators. A detailed analysis of these conflicts is outside the scope of this document: they require a separate dataset (UCDP, ACLED).

23. The “Flashpoint monitor” module in the programme

The military power index answers the question “who is stronger”, but not the question “where a war will begin”. For this reason the programme includes a separate module — the flashpoint monitor with a tension index for each country pair.

Tension index component	Data source	Default weight
Active combat operations and casualties	UCDP, ACLED	25%
Frequency of incidents (air, sea, border)	open sources, government agencies	15%
Territorial dispute and leaders' rhetoric	expert assessment, content analysis	15%
Dynamics of the balance of forces (change in the MPI over a year)	programme calculation	15%
Allied involvement and the reliability of guarantees	coalition module	10%
Internal instability of the parties	V-Dem, WGI, UCDP	10%
Nuclear factor (target limitation)	SIPRI, deterrence class	10%

Module interface: a world map with tension colouring, an event feed for each flashpoint, an “Open scenario” button with preconfigured sides and coalitions, and a monthly history of the tension index.

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